third member of the five-man board due to retire by the month-end, and a fourth having been changed just a month earlier, Choudhury had achieved the clean sweep he had threatened during his now famous press conference the previous December.

The broom reached one rung lower: about a dozen heads of departments in the Railway Board were simultaneously transferred to the most out-of-the-way stations. Many of them had been Gujral's most trusted aides and closest colleagues, hand-picked by him for key slots .

In dismissing Gujral and Lal, Choudhury had made use of the prime minister's January directive to dispense with the service of superannuated officers: both Gujral and Lal were on extension. But Gujral's sacking was clearly not what Mrs Gandhi had intended.

As early as last December, Choudhury had sent a proposal to replace Gujral with Lal, and failed to get clearance from the Cabinet's Appointments Committee. Now, using a handle conveniently within his reach, Choudhury had clearly upstaged Mrs Gandhi and presented her with a fait accompli.

The dismissals and transfers were carried out with a vengeance, and with all the drama of a coup d'etat. Gujral, on tour in Bombay, was informed of his dismissal over the telephone. Lal was served with a cheque for three months' salary in lieu of notice, and promptly left his office.

The name plates of these and other officers were removed with indecent haste, their rooms immediately locked; in some cases, sealed cupboards were shifted to other offices. The transferred officers were asked to report at their new posts in two days—often at locations two days' train journeys away. Many of them, in their new postings, would have to report to officers junior to them in the service hierarchy.

Gujral took his dismissal philosophically, seeing himself as the vanquished hero going down in a blaze of glory. 'I have no regrets. I have had more than a full innings, and taken the railways to the pinnacle of their performance.' [14 1]

SURVEY OF INDIA'S 'EXTREME RAILWAY' ON BIKES

This is the fascinating story of the beginnings of India's 'Extreme Railway', as British TV presenter Chris Tarrant calls the 760-km Konkan Railway. This narrative is about how railway pioneers built offices in a week and